

Free Compliance Workshops Did Not Reduce Violations or Pollution, Study Finds

An approach promoted as an alternative to inspections and fines showed no measurable effect on the facilities it was meant to help.

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Offering polluting facilities free help to follow environmental regulations did not make them any more likely to follow them, according to a new study of hundreds of wastewater treatment plants in Ohio. The research, published by Paul J. Ferraro and Jay P. Shimshack in the *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, found that compliance workshops had no detectable effect on either violations or the amount of pollution facilities discharged.

The workshops are based on the belief that many facilities break the rules out of confusion rather than deliberate corner-cutting. They had appeared to work — violations dropped by more than 50 percent afterward — but Ferraro and Shimshack found the same decline at facilities that had signed up but were not yet trained. Trained facilities violated the rules just as often, and discharged just as much pollution, as those still waiting; even tracking the same facilities over time, violations did not fall in the months after a workshop. That drop, in other words, reflected a broader downward trend, not the workshops.

Ferraro and Shimshack stress that one program in one state isn't a verdict on compliance assistance everywhere. The evidence behind inspections and penalties is far stronger, though — and with enforcement budgets already shrinking, every dollar redirected to compliance assistance risks more violations and more pollution, not less.

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The Environmental Inequality Lab is a nonpartisan research group that applies a rigorous, data-driven approach to understand how our environment shapes economic opportunity and well-being.

Full paper: doi.org/10.1002/pam.70056 · Research highlight: [\[link\]](#)